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Ethical Leadership Interview Analysis

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Beyond Compliance: Ethical Leadership Through Empathy and Integrity in Public Service

Introduction

Ethical leadership is a cornerstone of effective governance in both public and nonprofit sectors. It extends beyond simply following rules or enforcing codes of conduct—ethical leadership is about creating a culture rooted in integrity, accountability, and respect.Ethical leaders inspire others through their actions, make decisions guided by core values, and maintain a commitment to transparency and fairness. Their influence extends beyond immediate decisions, shaping organizational culture and empowering employees to act ethically, even in challenging situations.

This paper presents an analysis of two ethical leaders from distinct sectors: a Police Lieutenant from the Rutgers University Police Department (RUPD) in Newark and the CEO of Burlington Community Action Partnership, Inc. The Lieutenant's leadership is characterized by direct support, integrity, and leading by example, while the CEO's leadership is rooted in transparency, accountability, and servant leadership. Their stories reveal that ethical leadership is not a one-size-fits-all concept but rather a dynamic process shaped by context, values, and individual commitment.

The analysis begins with a detailed examination of the two leaders' experiences, highlighting their leadership philosophies, ethical challenges, and decision-making processes. It then explores the common themes that emerge from their stories, followed by an in-depth analysis of how these themes align with ethical theories from Cooper (2006) and Johnson (2017). Finally, the paper presents a description of the Compleat Ethical Leader, synthesizing

the insights gained from both interviews and demonstrating the qualities essential to ethical leadership.

Police Lieutenant (RUPD Newark)

The Police Lieutenant's leadership is rooted in integrity, empathy, and leading by example. His guiding principle is best captured by his statement: *"Never ask those that work for you to do something you wouldn't do yourself."* He further emphasized, *"Leadership means leading from the front, not from the top."* These principles are not just slogans—they are the foundation of his leadership approach.

One of the most impactful stories he shared involved supporting a subordinate facing a personal crisis. Rather than ignoring the situation, he facilitated access to counseling and provided time off, demonstrating that empathy is a core aspect of his leadership. His decision to offer direct support not only helped the individual but also reinforced a culture of trust within the department.

Inclusivity is another cornerstone of his leadership. When a team member began a gender transition, he proactively advocated for their fair treatment, ensuring that they felt safe and respected. He openly communicated with the team and promoted understanding, reducing potential conflict and fostering acceptance. *"Everyone deserves to be treated with dignity,"* he emphasized, *"regardless of who they are or how they identify."* For the Lieutenant, ethical leadership is about creating an environment where everyone is treated with dignity.

His ethical resilience is further demonstrated in his management of public demonstrations. Balancing public safety with respect for individual rights, he consistently maintained a calm and fair approach. In one instance, when a protest became tense, he personally stepped forward to communicate with demonstrators, de-escalating the situation without compromising public safety. His decisions were guided by fairness, accountability, and respect for all individuals involved.

Reflecting on his leadership, he expressed his desire to be remembered as a leader who stood with his team, supported them, and never asked them to do something he would not do

himself. *"If you're not training your replacement, you're failing as a leader,"* he stated, emphasizing his belief in preparing future leaders. For him, ethical leadership is a continuous journey defined by actions, not just words.

CEO (Burlington Community Action Partnership)

The CEO's leadership philosophy is defined by accountability, transparency, and servant leadership. Her belief in ethical leadership is best summarized by her quote: *"Ethical leadership is about being accountable not just to the Board, but to the community you serve."* This commitment to accountability is not just theoretical—it is a principle she has demonstrated in practice.

A defining moment in her leadership journey occurred when she uncovered unethical practices by a previous CEO. Rather than remaining silent, she chose to report these concerns to the Board of Trustees—a decision that led to leadership changes, restored trust, and reinforced ethical governance. This courageous act demonstrated that ethical leadership sometimes requires challenging the status quo, even at personal risk.

Her servant leadership is evident in her dedication to staff development. She mentors her team, encourages them to pursue professional growth, and creates opportunities for advancement. *"I believe in creating leaders, not followers. If my team can thrive without me, I've done my job right,"* she explained. This approach fosters a culture of mutual respect and accountability, where ethical behavior is encouraged at all levels.

Transparency is another core value in her leadership. She ensures that organizational decisions align with the mission and values of the organization. Inspired by Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s wisdom, *"The time is always right to do what is right,"* she consistently prioritizes ethical decision-making, ensuring that the organization remains accountable to the communities it serves.

Comparative Analysis

Both leaders demonstrate a strong commitment to ethical leadership, but their approaches differ significantly. The Police Lieutenant leads through direct action, providing immediate support to his team, resolving conflicts, and maintaining accountability. His leadership is grounded in hands-on engagement, where he models ethical behavior through his actions. In contrast, the CEO's leadership is strategic, emphasizing transparency, accountability, and systemic change. Her decision to report unethical practices reflects a willingness to challenge unethical behavior, even at personal risk. Her servant leadership is evident in her focus on mentorship and staff empowerment, creating a culture where ethical values are consistently practiced.

Despite these differences, both leaders share common values that define their ethical leadership:

- **Integrity:** Both maintain a commitment to honesty and fairness, even in difficult situations. The Lieutenant demonstrates integrity by leading from the front and holding himself to the same standards he expects of his team. The CEO models integrity through transparency, holding herself and her organization accountable to ethical principles.
- **Empathy:** They recognize the importance of understanding and supporting others. The Lieutenant offers direct support during personal crises, while the CEO fosters professional growth and development, ensuring that her team feels valued and empowered.
- **Transparency:** They communicate openly, ensuring that their actions align with their values. The Lieutenant maintains transparency in crisis management, while the CEO ensures that decisions reflect the organization's mission and values.
- **Accountability:** Both accept responsibility for their actions and decisions. The Lieutenant holds himself accountable to his team, leading by example, while the CEO is accountable not only to the Board but also to the community she serves.
- **Resilience:** They uphold ethical principles, even when faced with adversity. The Lieutenant maintains fairness and composure during tense public demonstrations, while

the CEO demonstrates resilience by challenging unethical practices despite the personal risks involved.

- **Courage:** Both leaders are willing to make difficult decisions in the interest of ethical integrity. The Lieutenant stands firm in his values even under public scrutiny, while the CEO exemplifies moral courage by reporting unethical behavior, even at the risk of her own position.

Together, these leaders illustrate that ethical leadership can take many forms, but it is always grounded in a commitment to core values. Whether through direct action or systemic advocacy, they demonstrate that ethical leadership is not about authority—it is about influence, integrity, and the courage to do what is right.

Ultimately, their ethical values did more than guide their own actions—they shaped the behavior and mindset of those they led. The Lieutenant's team absorbed the importance of integrity and resilience by witnessing his unwavering support and principled decision-making, while the CEO's staff experienced the power of transparency and accountability through her open communication and ethical advocacy. The Police Lieutenant exemplifies ethical leadership through direct support, crisis management, and leading by example, fostering a culture of trust and cohesion. In contrast, the CEO embodies ethical leadership through transparency, advocacy, and systemic change, prioritizing accountability to both the organization and the community it serves.

Connection to Ethical Theories (Cooper and Johnson)

According to Cooper's ethical framework, both leaders demonstrate democratic accountability. The Police Lieutenant's commitment to inclusivity, supporting a transitioning officer, aligns with Cooper's principle of responsibility to all stakeholders (Cooper, 2006). His transparency in crisis management further reflects accountability.

The CEO's actions embody Cooper's principles of transparency and ethical governance. Her decision to report unethical practices aligns with her responsibility to the Board and the community. Johnson's concept of servant leadership is also evident. The CEO fosters staff

development and ethical empowerment, while the Lieutenant models integrity by leading from the front (Johnson, 2017).

Johnson's concept of "casting light" is also visible in both leaders' actions. The Lieutenant leads by example, providing hands-on support, while the CEO's courageous stance against unethical practices represents ethical leadership in action. Both leaders model integrity, demonstrating that ethical leadership is about influence, not authority.

The Compleat Public Sector/Nonprofit Sector Ethical Leader

An ethical leader in the public and nonprofit sectors embodies a commitment to integrity, transparency, empathy, accountability, and resilience. Such leaders are not defined by their titles or positions but by their actions. They recognize that ethical leadership is not just about making the right decisions—it is about creating a culture where ethical values are consistently practiced, empowering others to lead with integrity.

A Compleat Ethical Leader demonstrates several essential qualities that distinguish them from others:

- **Integrity:** Ethical leaders consistently make decisions aligned with ethical values, even under pressure. They do not compromise their principles for convenience or personal gain. Integrity is evident in both the Police Lieutenant, who leads by example and upholds fairness in every interaction, and the CEO, who challenges unethical practices even when it places her position at risk. Integrity means being honest, transparent, and committed to doing what is right, even when it is difficult.
- **Empathy:** Ethical leaders understand and respect the perspectives and experiences of others. They recognize that leadership is about people, and they take the time to listen, support, and guide their teams. The Police Lieutenant demonstrates empathy by offering direct support to a team member in crisis, while the CEO fosters an environment of growth and empowerment, encouraging her team to pursue professional development. Empathy allows leaders to build trust and foster a culture of respect.

- **Resilience:** Ethical leaders maintain their commitment to ethical values even in the face of adversity. They do not shy away from difficult situations or compromise their principles to avoid conflict. The Police Lieutenant's calm and fair management of public demonstrations, even when faced with tension, reflects resilience. Similarly, the CEO's willingness to report unethical practices, despite the personal risks involved, demonstrates moral courage. Resilience is the ability to stand firm in ethical principles, even when under pressure.
- **Transparency:** Ethical leaders communicate openly and honestly, ensuring that their actions align with their values. They understand that transparency builds trust and accountability. The CEO demonstrates transparency by ensuring that organizational decisions reflect the mission and values of the organization. The Police Lieutenant's openness in addressing sensitive issues, such as supporting a transitioning officer, promotes a culture of honesty and acceptance.
- **Accountability:** Ethical leaders take responsibility for their actions and decisions, recognizing that their behavior sets the standard for others. They do not shift blame or avoid responsibility when mistakes occur. The Police Lieutenant holds himself accountable to his team, leading by example and maintaining fairness. The CEO models accountability by reporting unethical practices, recognizing that ethical leadership requires holding herself and others to high standards.
- **Courage:** Ethical leaders are willing to take risks in defense of ethical principles. They understand that doing what is right is not always easy, but it is always necessary. Courage is demonstrated by the CEO, who chose to report unethical practices despite the potential consequences. It is also evident in the Police Lieutenant, who consistently stands with his team, even in challenging situations. Courage is the willingness to act with integrity, even when facing resistance.
- **Empowerment:** Ethical leaders inspire and develop future leaders. They do not seek to maintain control—they seek to create an environment where others can thrive. The CEO's commitment to mentorship and staff development reflects this principle, while

the Police Lieutenant's focus on training and preparing future leaders demonstrates his belief in empowering others.

The Compleat Ethical Leader is not defined by perfection but by a continuous commitment to ethical excellence. They understand that ethical leadership is a journey—one that requires constant self-reflection, learning, and growth. They lead by example, inspire others to act with integrity, and create a culture where ethical values are not just stated but practiced consistently.

Such leaders are a source of stability in times of crisis, a voice of reason in moments of uncertainty, and a model of integrity in an era where ethical behavior is often challenged. They demonstrate that true leadership is not about authority—it is about influence, empowerment, and the courage to do what is right, regardless of the circumstances.

Conclusion

Creating an ethical culture within an organization is about more than just policies and codes of conduct—it requires leaders who consistently model ethical behavior, foster open communication, and integrate integrity into every decision they make. Ethical leadership is not simply about avoiding unethical behavior; it is about actively promoting values such as honesty, fairness, empathy, and accountability. Leaders who embody these values not only inspire trust but also empower their teams to act with integrity, even in difficult situations.

The stories of the Police Lieutenant and the CEO illustrate that ethical leadership can take many forms, but it is always rooted in the same core principles. The Lieutenant leads by example, supporting his team members during personal crises, advocating for inclusivity, and maintaining a calm, respectful demeanor during public demonstrations. His actions reflect a commitment to fairness and integrity, guided by his philosophy of "leading from the front, not from the top." For him, ethical leadership means standing alongside his team, demonstrating courage and compassion through direct action.

The CEO's leadership, on the other hand, is defined by transparency, accountability, and servant leadership. Her decision to report unethical practices, even at the risk of her own

position, demonstrates moral courage. Her commitment to mentoring and developing her team reflects an understanding that ethical leadership is not just about making the right decisions—it is about empowering others to do the same. Inspired by Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s wisdom, *"The time is always right to do what is right,"* she ensures that her organization operates with integrity, accountability, and a clear sense of purpose.

Together, these two leaders demonstrate that ethical leadership is about more than personal values—it is about creating an environment where those values are consistently practiced. Their experiences reveal that true ethical leadership requires more than just good intentions; it requires action, resilience, and a willingness to confront challenges head-on. Whether through direct support or systemic advocacy, they show that ethical leadership can transform organizations, strengthen communities, and build trust among stakeholders.

Ultimately, ethical leadership is a continuous journey—one that demands self-awareness, adaptability, and an unwavering commitment to doing what is right. An ethical leader is not defined by their position or authority but by their ability to influence and inspire others. They are a source of stability in times of crisis, a voice of reason in moments of uncertainty, and a model of integrity when ethical behavior is challenged. Ethical leaders do not command respect—they earn it. Leaders who embrace this journey not only strengthen their own credibility but also inspire others to lead with integrity, fostering a culture of ethical excellence that extends far beyond their immediate influence. As the stories of the Police Lieutenant and the CEO reveal, ethical leadership is not just about personal values—it is about creating an environment where those values are consistently practiced, transforming individuals, organizations, and communities

References

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